



Topkapi emerald dagger

△ **Sultan Mahmud I**, who commissioned the dagger

This celebrated emerald dagger is the star attraction of the Topkapi Palace Museum in Istanbul, Turkey. It is one of the finest objects of its kind, but its origins are inextricably linked with bloodshed and treachery.

It was made in Istanbul in the mid-18th century by the royal craftsmen of the Ottoman ruler, Sultan Mahmud I, most likely as a diplomatic gift for the Persian leader, Nadir Shah. Later known as “the Napoleon of Persia”, Nadir Shah was the most powerful military figure in the region, and he had recently waged a bitter war against the Ottomans.

The two countries made peace in 1746 and exchanged gifts. Mahmud’s contribution included the spectacular dagger. This was a shrewd choice, as Nadir’s fondness for jewels was well known – he had seized many during his campaigns in India, including the Koh-i-noor diamond (see pp.58–59).



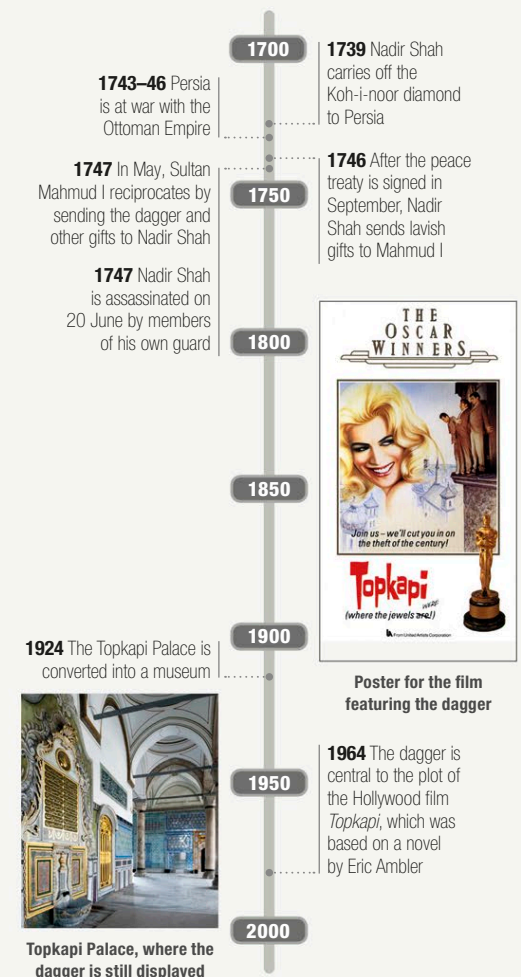
The Topkapi dagger, comprising gold set with emeralds and diamonds

The dagger is dominated by the huge emeralds in its handle. In the Islamic world, emeralds were highly prized and exotic – these are thought to originate from the Muzo mines in Colombia. The main upper and lower emeralds are pear-shaped, while the middle one has a rectangular cushion cut. Another octagonal emerald on top of the handle lifts to reveal a watch. The handle and sheath consist of gold set with diamonds, with enamel and mother-of-pearl decoration.

Nadir Shah never lived to see the dagger: while the gifts were in transit, he was assassinated in his bed. Upon hearing the news, the escort party returned home and the dagger was placed in Topkapi Palace, where it is still on display. Its popularity grew in 1964, when the heist film *Topkapi* depicted a fictitious plot to steal the dagger, winning actor Peter Ustinov an Oscar.

Key dates

1739–1964



The emerald-set cover at the top of the handle opens to reveal a gold watch

... the famous Istanbul dagger contains the four world’s most priceless emeralds

Topkapi film
1964